Wealthfront

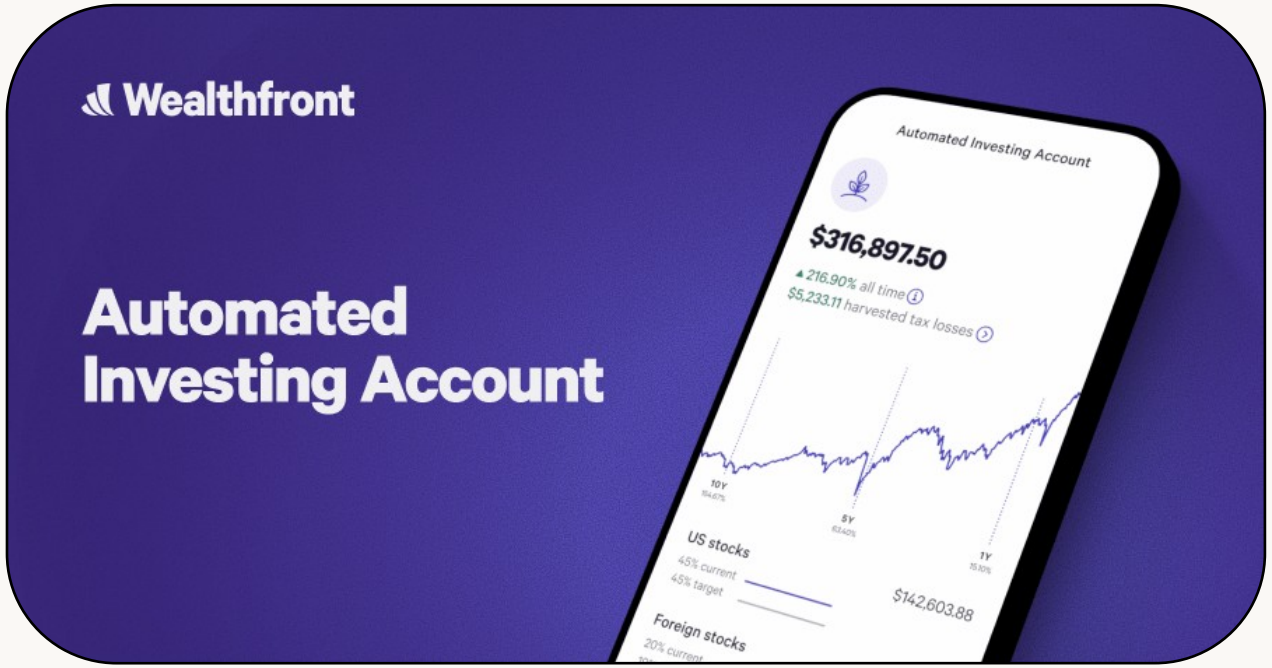
Money works better here.

NASDAQ · WLTH

wealthfront

CASE STUDY

CASE QUESTION | How did a weak first hypothesis become a scalable financial platform?

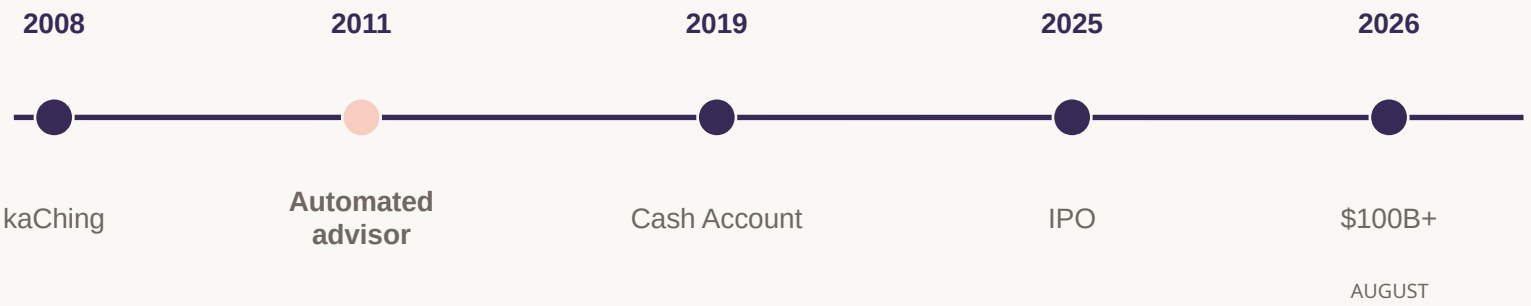


Luca Giordanino · Introduction to FinTech (USI)

Independent student case study · Not affiliated with or endorsed by Wealthfront

1 · SITUATION

Right place, right moment



THE MARKET

Young Silicon Valley wealth

THE INDUSTRY

High fees · human-intensive advice · high minimums

CONTEXT

Post-crisis distrust + digital finance adoption

The real pivot was a change in belief

kaChing

“Find the wizard.”

MARKET LEARNING

Wealthfront · 2011

“Stop picking winners.”

THEORY → FINTECH IMPLEMENTATION

Malkiel joined as CIO in 2012

MALKIEL

Why stop searching?

MARKOWITZ

How should we invest?

WEALTHFRONT

How do we deliver it?

The pivot worked — but robo-advice was not enough

FY2026 REVENUE · $365.0M · YEAR ENDED JAN. 31, 2026



Revenue: $271.7M cash · $91.9M advisory · $1.4M other

1.5M+	$100B+	391
funded clients	platform assets	employees[1]

as of Jan. 31, 2026

Clients and platform assets: August 2026

WEALTH PLATFORM

WEALTHFRONT TODAY

From robo-advisor to financial platform

Cash	Short-term savings
Bonds	Bond portfolios & ladders
Automated Investing	Managed diversified portfolios
Stocks	Self-directed investing
Home Lending	Digital mortgages

Sources: Wealthfront FY2026 10-K; Sept. 2026 investor update.

What Wealthfront actually teaches us

01

Fall in love with the problem, not the first solution.

02

Product-market fit ≠ sustainable economics.

03

FinTech often scales existing finance through better delivery.

Wealthfront won by updating both the investment hypothesis and the business model.

Money works better here.

APPENDIX

Sources

Selected primary and contextual references · Click a source to open it.

01	Wealthfront FY2026 Form 10-K — revenue, employees, IPO and business model.	OPEN
02	Wealthfront Investor Relations (Sep. 2026) — clients and $100B assets milestone.	OPEN
03	Wealthfront Blog (Dec. 2011) — launch of its automated online adviser.	OPEN
04	Stanford GSB (2014), Wealthfront, case E477 — early strategic pivots.	OPEN
05	TechCrunch (Dec. 2011) — transition to automated investment advice.	OPEN
06	Wealthfront website — Cash, Investing, Bonds, Stocks and Home Lending.	OPEN
07	Wealthfront Design — focus, clarity and customer-first experiences.	OPEN
08	ICI, 2011 Investment Company Fact Book — context on the ETF market.	OPEN

APPENDIX

Method & definitions

A few caveats behind the numbers.

Platform assets	All financial assets held by clients on the platform; broader than advisory AUM.
Cash management revenue	Fees Wealthfront receives through its cash-sweep arrangements with program banks.
Investment advisory revenue	Fees charged for advisory and portfolio-management services.
Malkiel / Markowitz link	Used as a theoretical lens on the pivot; not claimed as the causal reason for it.
Case-study limitation	The case can illustrate mechanisms and lessons, but cannot prove causality or counterfactuals.

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